

Prompt Engineering

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Week 5: Controlling Style, Tone, and Format

Where We Are

- Prior weeks established fundamentals and reusable pattern frameworks.
- **This week:** Focus on precise control of style, tone, register, and structured formatting without rehashing basics.

Weekly Learning Objectives

- Rapidly profile audience and medium to derive tone/register parameters.
- Operationalize voice guidelines (brand, compliance, cultural sensitivity) in compact prompt clauses.
- Specify parse-ready output (tables / JSON / labeled sections) aligned to downstream pipeline needs.
- Instrument prompts for self-audit to catch tone, register, or formatting drift.
- Produce lightweight, reusable micro style guides for collaborative human–AI drafting.

Key Concepts

- Tone ladder calibration vs. tone adjectives
- Voice fingerprint (syntax rhythm, perspective, lexical field)
- Register levers (jargon density, sentence length, metaphor frequency)
- Structural contracts (schema / heading spec / placeholder tokens)
- Drift detection and corrective refinement loops

Quick Question: Which Email Would You Send?

Version A

Subject: Payment Due
Your invoice is overdue. Please pay as soon as possible. If you have questions, contact us.
Thanks.

Version B

Subject: Friendly Payment Reminder
Hi [Name],
We haven't received payment for Invoice #2847 (due Nov 1). We understand things get busy!
Could you please submit payment by Nov 10? Reply if you need help.
Thank you for your business!

Quick poll: A, B, or Depends?

Three dimensions of register control:

- **Field (Topic Domain):** Controls terminology density and specialization.
 - Technical: *myocardial infarction, hemodynamic instability*
 - Lay: *heart attack, blood pressure problems*
- **Tenor (Relationship):** Manages power distance and social connection.
 - Authority: *You must submit... , I recommend...*
 - Peer: *Let's review... , What do you think?*
 - Subordinate: *Would it be possible... , I'd appreciate...*
- **Mode (Channel):** Adjusts for delivery style and planning.
 - Written-planned: complete sentences, cohesive structure
 - Spoken-spontaneous: fragments, fillers, self-correction

Multi-Dimensional Register Specifications

Instead of vague instructions:

- “Be professional” → ambiguous
- “Make it friendly” → inconsistent results

Use precise dimensional specs:

- CEFR B1 + peer tenor + written-planned mode
- Domain: healthcare lay + subordinate tenor + email mode
- Technical depth: expert + authority tenor + monologic

Result: Precise, reproducible style control without trial-and-error.

Step 1: Audience Analysis

- Industry context: legal (risk-averse), tech (innovation-forward), healthcare (empathetic)
- Reading level: CEFR B1 (general public) vs. C2 (domain experts)
- Cultural norms: directness (US/Germany) vs. indirectness (Japan/Middle East)

Step 2: Tone Mapping

- Vague adjectives → Observable behaviors
- *Warm*: Use names, express gratitude, acknowledge effort
- *Urgent*: Short sentences, action verbs, explicit deadlines
- *Neutral*: Third-person, passive constructions, hedge words

Voice and Tone Diagnostics (continued)

Step 3: No-Go Zones

- Banned words: *cheap, guarantee, revolutionary, disrupt*
- Prohibited claims: *We're the best, FDA-approved (if not true)*
- Brand sensitivities: competitor names, controversial topics

Step 4: Provide Exemplars

- **Strong sample:** *Thanks for your patience. We've resolved the issue and added extra support hours.*
- **Counter-example:** *Your ticket was processed. Issue closed.*
- **Why it matters:** AI learns boundaries from contrasts, not just positive examples.

Concept

Extract measurable, reproducible voice attributes from existing content to ensure AI outputs match your brand.

Four dimensions to capture:

- 1 **Syntax signature:** Measure sentence structure patterns
- 2 **Lexical field:** Identify preferred vocabulary choices
- 3 **Rhythm:** Analyze pacing and variety
- 4 **Perspective:** Determine point-of-view consistency

Brand Voice Fingerprinting: Measurable Attributes

Syntax Signature

- Avg. sentence length: 12–18 words
- Clause complexity: 1.5 clauses/sentence
- Passive voice: <10%

Lexical Field

- Preferred: *enable, drive, foster*
- Avoid: *leverage, synergy, utilize*

Process: Analyze 3–5 approved samples → Extract metrics → Encode as prompt constraints

Rhythm

- Sentence length variance: high
- Fragment usage: occasional for emphasis
- Lists: 3–5 items, parallel structure

Perspective

- First-person plural: “We help you. . .”
- vs. Institutional: “The platform provides. . .”

Style Guides in Prompts

- Embed condensed brand voice manuals: values, vocabulary, cadence.
- Use bullet checklists to anchor style: “Always include...”, “Never include...”.
- Request self-audit — *List 3 style guidelines you followed before the final answer.*
- Maintain iterative memory with conversation tags (e.g., StyleGuide v2).

Tone Shift Mechanics: Instruction Levers

Core Insight

Small, atomic prompt changes yield predictable tone movement.

- **Contraction control:** *Avoid contractions → formal; Use contractions → casual.*
- **Sentence directive:** *Use short, direct sentences vs. Use complex, flowing prose.*
- **Affective markers:** *Include gratitude and empathy vs. Use neutral, objective language.*
- **Urgency cues:** *Emphasize deadline and consequences vs. Provide context without pressure.*
- Test each lever in isolation to measure effect size.

Register and Reading Level

- Specify reading grade (CEFR level, Flesch-Kincaid, Common European levels).
- Ask for analogies or metaphors suited to audience background.
- Include domain-specific vocabulary lists to use or avoid.
- Prompt for translanguaging — *Introduce one Turkish idiom and translate it.*

Structural Contracts: Parse-Ready Output

Concept

A structural contract is an explicit, testable specification for output shape.

- **Why?** Downstream automation (APIs, DBs, dashboards) requires predictable format.
- **Components:** section labels, field names, data types, ordering rules.
- **Enforcement:** request model to echo the contract before generating content.
- **Validation hook:** *If any required field is missing, output INCOMPLETE and list missing fields.*

Structured Output Techniques

- Define exact headings, table columns, or JSON fields.
- Use placeholders: <Intro>, <Key Risks>, <Call to Action>.
- Enforce ordering: numbered lists, priority ranking, timeline progression.
- Incorporate validation prompts — *Confirm all fields are filled; note any missing data.*

Schema Enforcement

- Provide schema with types and constraints.
- Ask model to restate schema pre-output to ensure alignment.
- Encourage graceful failure — *If you cannot comply, return `VALIDATION_ERROR`.*

Example

Return JSON array of objects with keys:

- task (string, sentence case)
- tone (one of: neutral, upbeat, urgent)
- word_limit (integer, 50-200)
- notes (array of 1-3 short strings)

Only output JSON.

Multi-Channel Formatting

- Build variants: email, SMS, chatbot, longform doc.
- Use conditional instructions — *If channel=SMS, limit to 160 characters.*
- Include metadata for automation: tags, CTA keywords, compliance flags.
- Request summary + main content for editorial review workflows.

Challenge

Different stakeholders (legal, marketing, product) impose conflicting voice rules.

- **Strategy 1 — Layered prompts:** Legal disclaimers as append-only; marketing tone for body.
- **Strategy 2 — Priority matrix:** Encode rule precedence (compliance > brand > preference).
- **Strategy 3 — Modular outputs:** Generate compliant core + stylized wrapper separately; merge post-hoc.
- Document conflicts in a decision log; iterate with stakeholder input.

Detecting Drift

- Prompt for reflection — *Describe how this output aligns with tone X.*
- Use comparison prompts — *Compare to sample and note deviations.*
- Run batch consistency checks with templated critique prompts.
- Employ versioning: keep changelog of style guide tweaks.

Revision Loops

- Phase 1: Draft with full instructions.
- Phase 2: Critique focusing on tone, compliance, formatting.
- Phase 3: Revise using critique as structured feedback.
- Escalate to human review when checks fail twice.

Programmatic Tone Testing

Concept

Automate tone evaluation by embedding test prompts in your pipeline.

- **Self-labeling:** Ask model to classify its own tone (formal / neutral / casual).
- **Reference comparison:** Provide gold-standard sample; request deviation score (0–10).
- **Sentiment analysis:** Use lightweight NLP tool to measure valence and arousal.
- **Readability metrics:** Flesch-Kincaid, SMOG index for grade-level verification.
- Run tests on batch outputs; flag outliers for manual review.

Healthcare: Patient Outreach

- Audience: adult patients, B1 reading level.
- Tone: empathetic, reassuring; include disclaimer.
- Format: 3 bullets + call to action button text.
- Validation: highlight any missing appointment data.

Before: Generic, no tone control, missing validation.

After: Empathy markers, B1 vocabulary, graceful failure for missing fields.

Finance: Investor Update

- Voice: confident, transparent, data-led.
- Include table (metric, Q2 value, delta vs. Q1).
- Provide macro context paragraph and risk disclosure statement.
- Request internal summary for leadership in 100 words.

Before: Unstructured narrative, no quantitative anchor.

After: Multi-format output (table + paragraphs), dual audiences (investors + internal).

Education: Lesson Plan Variants

- Generate two versions: 6th grade science, undergraduate seminar.
- Tone shift from playful to scholarly.
- Format: table with sections (Hook, Core Content, Activity, Assessment).
- Reflection: note adjustments made for each audience.

Before: Single-register output, no audience differentiation.

After: Parallel outputs with explicit register shift + meta-commentary on changes.

Legal-Marketing Hybrid: Product Announcement

Scenario

Legal requires risk disclaimers; marketing wants upbeat, benefit-forward language.

- **Approach:** Two-pass generation.
- Pass 1: Marketing-optimized body (tone: upbeat; focus: user benefits).
- Pass 2: Append legal footer (tone: neutral; format: separate section with <Legal> tag).
- **Validation:** Confirm legal section is non-empty and placed after marketing content.

Outcome: Satisfies both stakeholders without tone bleed between sections.

Activity 1: Tone Ladder Workshop

Goal

Practice moving a message up and down the formality scale.

- Choose a baseline message (e.g., payment reminder).
- Produce five variants from *stern* to *friendly* using prompt tweaks.
- Annotate which instructions caused each shift.

Key Takeaways

- Tone and format control start with precise diagnostics.
- Combine style guides with structural constraints for reliability.
- Revision prompts catch drift and safeguard brand voice.
- Documented playbooks enable scalable human-AI collaboration.

Thank You!

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Questions?